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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1965-1966

Coverage Date: 1965 AD - 1966 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S): B) Ng'hula

When the party arrives back at the house, the boy arrives from the *kisepi's* house, ostensibly from the bush, his head covered by a cloth and escorted by the older men. He is seated on a stool placed on a mat so that he does not touch the earth. While some men hold up a large new cloth to form a screen, others remove his old clothes and put on a new loin-cloth, which is tied in such a manner as to resemble a pair of shorts. Two other cloths are rolled up and tied like bandoliers across his chest and shoulders. He is anointed with castor-oil by his father's sister and the men who are present, and then sprinkled with sorghum seed (the source of beer), and then placed on the shoulders of a man. It was not specified precisely who this man should be. As I mentioned, a girl would be carried by a future brother-in-law. For a boy it does not seem to be a matter of great importance. In the same sort of way the preparation of a girl for her debut is carried out in the utmost secrecy inside a hut, but for a boy the screening is perfunctory and children are able to watch what goes on. When the boy is carried shoulder-high, he observes the same custom as girls: his eyes are closed, he shakes and shimmies to the drum music and twitches a fly switch in his right hand. As occurs with girls, small pre-pubescent girls are often carried round on men's shoulders imitating the initiands, and providing them with an opportunity to rehearse their own debut. On one occasion a large adolescent boy, one of the initiands' joking partners, was carried round clowning the part, to laughter from the crowd. After circling the crowd for some time, the boy is lowered onto a mat in the doorway of his father's house, where he sits with his head partially covered with a cloth, while the two descent groups involved dance before him, and individuals dart forward to donate money. On one occasion cooked rice and catfish were handed round to the kindred and joking partners, who all ate together, men and women, standing up, simulating great haste. Finally, one of the joking partners tipped the last of the rice over the mother's head, and then the boy was carried inside the hut, exactly as a girl/bride would be. The guests disperse and the boy resumes his normal life the following day.

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